



OFF-SIDE

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FAMILIES BEFORE FANTASY

The **Online Gaming Act** forces Dream11 and MPL to exit, leaving Indian sport poorer but sparing families from the costs of compulsive play.

The Indian government's sweeping ban on real-money online gaming, outlined in the Promotion and Regulation of Online Gaming Act, 2025, has redrawn the country's sports economy. The new law outlaws money-based games, forcing companies such as Dream11 and MPL — two of the world's biggest fantasy sports operators and lead sponsors of the national cricket team and the Indian Premier League — to halt cash games and unwind contracts.

The Premier League in England had carried gambling logos on jerseys for over two decades before a 2023 vote to phase them out by 2026/27, bowing to irrefutable evidence of addiction and social harm. More than half of its 20 clubs had gambling sponsors — worth around £100 million a season — but the moral case prevailed. Fans' lives, argued regulators, outweighed balance sheets.

India has reached this conclusion more quickly, with the government opting for an outright ban rather than regulation.

The government's justification is rooted in public health. Parliament was informed that "between 2022 and June 2025, 1,524 betting and gambling websites and mobile apps were blocked" by the Centre. While the National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB) does not yet maintain a national category for suicides linked to online gaming, State-level data are troubling. Karnataka officials have acknowledged multiple suicides tied to online rummy and betting since 2023, while Tamil Nadu's Additional Public Prosecutor, E. Raj Thilak, representing the Director General of Police in June 2025, told a Division Bench of the Madras High Court that between 2019 and 2024 there were as many as 47 deaths by suicide due to

addiction to online games.

A government source told *PTI*: "There is a rough estimate that 45 crore people lose money every year. The total impact of the loss is estimated to be tentatively around ₹20,000 crore."

Lives lost to compulsive play could no longer be justified as collateral for sponsorship.

The decision, however, rips a gaping hole in Indian sports. Dream11 was not only the main sponsor of the national cricket team through a ₹358-crore, three-year jersey deal signed in 2023, it also bankrolled IPL franchises, domestic tournaments and dozens of athletes. Through its Dream Sports Foundation, the company backed Olympians such as sailor Nethra Kumanan and table tennis player Sreeja Akula, staged an Under-17 football championship, and funded grassroots school programmes. In terms of sheer visibility, very few private players have put more money into Indian sports over the past decade.

GroupM-ESP pegged India's 2024 sports market at ₹16,633 crore (sponsorships, endorsements, media), while according to TAM Media Research, Ecom-Gaming accounted for 6.84 per cent of advertising spend during IPL 2025. The abrupt loss of a category leader could result in a reduction of ₹500-₹1,000 crore in the sports market, with smaller leagues feeling the impact most acutely.

In England, analysts forecast that clubs outside the Premier League's "Big Six" could see shirt sponsorship values halved when gambling logos disappear.

But sport cannot claim to inspire communities while being propped up by industries that destabilise those same communities. Jerseys can live without gaming and gambling money, but families cannot live without loved ones.